

MK PARRISH · MKPARRISH.COM

WRITE YOURSELF INTO THE ROOM



The personal brand writing guide for people tired of sounding like everyone else.

BY MK PARRISH · \$39

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INTRO: THE ROOM YOU KEEP GETTING LEFT OUT OF

There is a room you want to be in. A client roster, an investor's shortlist, a curated panel, a feed where the people you admire actually read your stuff. And you keep getting left just outside the door, not because you lack the goods, but because your words do not carry them.

Here is the hard part nobody says out loud: the people in that room are not always more qualified than you. They are more **legible**. They have written themselves in clear, specific language while you have been hiding behind "results-driven professional passionate about leveraging synergies." You have made yourself unmemorable on purpose, because blandness feels safe. It is not. Blandness is how qualified people stay invisible.

This guide is about fixing that with words. Not louder words, sharper ones. We will cover a three-layer positioning framework, bio templates with real before-and-afters, a voice system you can actually run, a LinkedIn audit you can do today, and a thirty-day plan to put it all into the world. Every framework comes with examples, because positioning advice without examples is just a horoscope.

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You do not get into the room by being the loudest. You get in by being the clearest person they have read all week.

A note on how to use this book. You can read it straight through in an afternoon, and you should, the first time, so the logic stacks. But it is built to be worked, not just read. At the end of every chapter there is a section

called *Do The Work*, with prompts and exercises that turn the idea into your actual words on your actual page. Keep a notebook or an open document beside you. The people who get the most out of this are the ones who stop and write when the book tells them to. Reading about positioning will not reposition you. Writing will.

Pen up. Let's write you in.

CHAPTER ONE: WHY YOU SOUND LIKE EVERYONE ELSE

You sound like everyone else because you learned to write from everyone else.

You absorbed the LinkedIn dialect, "thought leader," "I'm humbled to announce," "passionate about driving impact," and mistook it for professionalism. It is not professionalism. It is camouflage. And camouflage works exactly backwards from what you want: it makes you blend into a landscape of identical profiles, all reciting the same dead phrases.

The root problem is fear dressed as polish. Specificity feels risky. If you say exactly what you do and who you are for, you might exclude someone. So you hedge. You generalize. You write "I help businesses grow" instead of "I help bootstrapped B2B founders write sales pages that do not sound like a robot wrote them." The first offends no one and attracts no one. The second is a magnet.

Generic writing is a decision to be forgettable in exchange for being safe. The whole rest of this book is an argument for making the opposite trade.

The four disguises of fear

Vague writing almost always traces back to one of four fears wearing a more respectable outfit. Learn to spot which one is yours, because you cannot fix a problem you keep mistaking for a virtue.

The fear of exclusion, disguised as inclusivity. You believe that naming a specific person you serve will turn away everyone else. The truth is the opposite. The general statement turns away everyone because it speaks

to no one in particular, and people do not hire the professional who might be able to help; they hire the one who clearly helps *people like them*. Specificity is not a wall that keeps people out. It is a flare that tells the right people you are talking to them.

The fear of arrogance, disguised as humility. You soften every claim because stating it plainly feels like bragging. So "I led the rebrand that doubled their enrollment" becomes "I was involved in various brand initiatives." Humility is a beautiful private virtue and a terrible public bio. On the page, what reads as humble usually just reads as vague, and vague reads as unsure, and unsure does not get invited into the room.

The fear of being pinned down, disguised as flexibility. You keep your language broad so you do not foreclose any option. But a person who could do anything reads as a person who is known for nothing. The market does not reward optionality. It rewards legibility. You can change your positioning next year. You cannot be remembered for a position you never took.

The fear of being seen, disguised as professionalism. This is the deepest one. Corporate language is a place to hide. The passive voice, the abstractions, the borrowed phrases, they all put distance between the reader and the actual person. Writing like a human means being visible as one, and visibility is the exact thing the frightened part of you is trying to avoid. Naming this is half the cure.

The cost of camouflage

We treat generic language as neutral, as if the worst it can do is fail to impress. It does worse than that. It actively costs you, and it costs you quietly, in decisions you never see being made.

Someone skims your bio and does not reach out, and you never know they were there. A hiring manager has you and another candidate, equal on paper, and chooses the one whose words made them feel something. A potential client reads "I help organizations achieve their goals" and feels

nothing, so they keep scrolling to the person who said the specific true thing. None of these people send you a rejection. They simply move on, and you experience it as a quiet, unexplained lack of momentum that you blame on the algorithm, the market, your luck. It is not your luck. It is your language.

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Vagueness is not humility. It is a failure to decide who you are out loud.

Do The Work

1. Pull up your current bio, LinkedIn headline, or website About page. Read it out loud, slowly, in your own voice.
2. Highlight every phrase that could appear, unchanged, on a competitor's page. Be ruthless. "Passionate," "results-driven," "proven track record," "dedicated to excellence," all of it.
3. Count the highlights. That number is your camouflage score. The rest of this book is about getting it to zero.
4. Now name your fear. Of the four disguises above, which one is driving your hedging? Write one sentence: "I write vaguely because I am afraid that ____." You will need this honesty in Chapter Two.

CHAPTER TWO: THE THREE-LAYER POSITIONING FRAMEWORK

Strong personal positioning is not a tagline. It is three layers stacked, each answering a different question. Get all three and your writing has a spine. Skip one and you sound like everyone else.

Layer One: The Category — What am I?

The plainest possible label for what you do. Not clever yet, clear. "Copywriter." "Fractional CFO." "Pediatric sleep coach." This is the shelf you live on. People cannot reach for you if they do not know which shelf to look on.

The mistake is skipping straight to clever. "Word alchemist" tells me nothing. Earn the cleverness in Layer Three. Layer One is load-bearing; keep it boring and true.

There is a quiet test for Layer One: could a stranger repeat it to a third person without getting confused? "She's a copywriter" travels. "She's a word alchemist" makes the listener tilt their head, and a head-tilt is friction, and friction is how referrals die in the hallway. Your category should move through a conversation frictionlessly, so the rest of your positioning can ride on top of it.

Layer Two: The Specific — Who exactly, and what exactly?

This is where most people quit too early. Layer Two narrows the category until it is unmistakably you. Who is your person? What is the precise outcome? What do you do that the average member of your category does not?

- Generic: "Copywriter for businesses."
- Layer Two: "Copywriter for wellness founders who are sick of sounding clinical and want to sound like a human who actually cares."

Narrowing feels like shrinking your market. It is the opposite. The more specific you are, the more the right person feels *that's me* and the more they will pay. Precision is premium.

There are three dials you can turn to find your Layer Two, and you do not need to max out all of them. Turn the ones that are most true.

- **Who.** The audience. Not "businesses," but "bootstrapped SaaS founders," "second-act women leaving corporate," "nonprofits under five million in budget."
- **What.** The outcome, stated concretely. Not "growth," but "email flows people actually open," "a website that finally explains what you do," "a board deck that does not put people to sleep."
- **How.** Your method or angle, if it is distinctive. "Without the month-long brand workshop." "In a single intensive day." "Using your own words, captured from interviews, not invented."

Combine two of these and you are already more specific than ninety percent of your field. Combine all three and you are nearly impossible to confuse with anyone else.

Layer Three: The Edge — Why me and not the other one?

Your point of view. The belief that puts daylight between you and the next person with the same skills. This is where voice and conviction live. What do you believe about your work that not everyone in your field agrees

with?

- "I think most brand voice work fails because it decorates instead of deciding. I make brands choose who they are, then write from it."

That is a stance. Stances are sticky. People remember the person who believes something over the person who lists services.

The fastest way to find your edge is to finish three sentences: "Most people in my field think ____, but I think ____." "The advice everyone gives that I disagree with is ____." "The thing I refuse to do, even though it is standard in my industry, is ____." Your honest answers to those are your Layer Three. An edge is not a marketing invention. It is a conviction you already hold and have been too polite to say in public.

Putting It Together

Stack the three into a positioning statement you can actually use:

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"I'm a [Layer One] for [Layer Two], who believes [Layer Three]."

Worked example: "I'm a brand strategist for second-act founders, people building the thing they were too scared to build at 28, who believes your story is your strongest asset and you have been burying it under jargon."

Run yours through all three. If any layer is fuzzy, that is the layer your writing is leaking through.

Three more worked examples, so you can see the dials turn

The accountant. Layer One: accountant. Layer Two: for freelance creatives who panic at tax time and have never once felt organized. Layer Three: who believes shame, not math, is what keeps people behind on their books, so the first job is to make you feel safe, not stupid. Stacked:

"I'm an accountant for freelance creatives who panic at tax time, and I believe the real problem was never the math, it was the shame, so I make the whole thing feel survivable first."

The developer. Layer One: web developer. Layer Two: for small brick-and-mortar businesses that got burned by a cheap agency. Layer Three: who believes most small businesses do not need a custom app, they need one fast, clear site that works, and will talk you out of the expensive thing you do not need. Stacked: "I build websites for local businesses that got burned last time, and I will happily talk you out of the expensive build you think you need."

The coach. Layer One: leadership coach. Layer Two: for newly promoted engineers who are suddenly managing their former peers. Layer Three: who believes the hardest part of management is not strategy, it is the awkward human conversations no one trained you for. Stacked: "I coach brand-new engineering managers through the awkward human conversations no one trained them for."

Notice that none of these are clever. They are clear. The cleverness, when it comes, lives in the voice, which is the next chapter but one. Get clear first.

Do The Work

1. Write your Layer One in three words or fewer. Boring is correct.
2. Turn the three dials for Layer Two: write your Who, your What, and your How as separate lines. Pick the two truest.
3. Finish the three edge sentences above. Circle the answer that scares you a little. That is usually the real one.
4. Assemble the full statement using the template. Then read it to one person who knows your work and watch their face. If they say "oh, that's exactly what you do," you have it. If they say "nice," keep going.

CHAPTER THREE: WRITING THE BIO (WITH REAL BEFORE & AFTERS)

Your bio is the most-read, least-considered thing you will ever write. People skim it in seven seconds and decide whether you are worth the room. Most bios waste those seconds on adjectives.

Three rules first:

1. **Lead with the reader's interest, not your résumé.** They care what you do *for them* before they care what you have done.
2. **One specific beats ten generals.** A single concrete detail ("I wrote the launch that took them to \$1M") outperforms a paragraph of "proven track record."
3. **Sound like a person.** Read it aloud. If you would not say it at dinner, cut it.

Template A — The Third-Person Professional Bio

Structure: [Name] + [Layer One/Two positioning] + [one proof with a number or name] + [point of view] + [human detail].

Before:

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"Jordan Ellis is a results-oriented marketing professional with over a decade of experience helping organizations achieve their goals through innovative, data-driven strategies."

Nothing in that sentence could not be said about ten thousand people. It is a fog.

After:

“*Jordan Ellis helps DTC skincare brands write email flows people actually open, work that has added seven figures to brands you have probably bought from. She thinks most email marketing fails because it sells before it earns the right to. She lives in Lisbon and has strong, unsolicited opinions about subject lines.*”

Specific. Opinionated. Human. You remember Jordan now.

Template B — The First-Person Short Bio (for sites, social, intros)

Structure: [What I do, plainly] + [for whom] + [the belief] + [a line of personality].

Before:

“*I'm a passionate freelance writer dedicated to crafting compelling content that drives engagement and delivers value to clients across various industries.*”

After:

“*I write the words founders are too close to their own work to find. Mostly for technical people who do extraordinary things and explain them like a tax form. I believe clarity is the highest form of respect. I have never once 'circled back' and I never will.*”

Template C — The One-Liner (for bylines, panels, the elevator)

Structure: [I help / I write] + [specific who] + [specific outcome], stated with a little teeth.

- **Before:** "Communications consultant and brand expert."
- **After:** "I help underestimated founders sound as formidable as they actually are."

The anatomy of a great opening line

Most bios live or die on the first sentence, because on most platforms it is the only sentence people read before deciding whether to read the second. A great opening line does one of three jobs. It names a sharp, specific outcome ("I write email flows people actually open"). It states a belief that makes you lean in ("I think most résumés are written to survive rejection, not to earn a yes"). Or it creates a small, honest surprise ("I got into branding because I was tired of watching brilliant people lose to mediocre marketers"). What it never does is warm up. "I am a seasoned professional with a passion for" is not an opening line. It is a throat-clear, and the reader is already gone.

Five more before-and-afters, fast

- **Before:** "Experienced project manager skilled in cross-functional collaboration." **After:** "I am the person they call when a project is three weeks late and everyone has stopped speaking to each other."

- **Before:** "Dedicated educator passionate about student success."
After: "I teach high schoolers to write essays that sound like them and still get the A. Both are possible. Most teachers pick one."
- **Before:** "Innovative designer with a keen eye for detail." **After:** "I design packaging for small food brands that have to win the shelf in two seconds with no ad budget."
- **Before:** "Strategic financial leader driving organizational value."
After: "I am a fractional CFO for founders who are great at the product and terrified of the spreadsheet."
- **Before:** "Versatile communications professional." **After:** "I translate brilliant, jargon-fluent scientists into humans the public will fund."

Read those afters out loud. Every one passes the dinner-table test. Not one contains an adjective doing the work a specific should be doing.

Do The Work

1. Write all three bio formats for yourself, A, B, and C. The one-liner last; it is just your three-layer positioning compressed.
2. For each, underline your single best concrete proof, a number, a name, a result. If you do not have one underlined, you are still hiding behind adjectives. Find the specific.
3. Run the dinner-table test on every sentence. Read it aloud. If you would not say it to a friend across a table, rewrite it until you would.
4. Delete one adjective per sentence and see if the sentence got stronger. It almost always did.

CHAPTER FOUR: VOICE — THE THING THAT ACTUALLY DIFFERENTIATES YOU

Two people can have identical positioning and sound nothing alike. That difference is voice, and it is the one thing a competitor cannot copy off your About page.

Voice is built from small, repeatable choices:

- **Sentence rhythm.** Do you run long and rolling, or short and clipped? Mix deliberately. A punch lands harder after a long sentence sets it up. Like that.
- **Diction.** Your actual words. Do you say "folks" or "executives"? "Gut" or "intuition"? Pick the register that is truly yours and commit.
- **What you refuse to say.** Voice is defined as much by your no-fly list as your vocabulary. Banning "synergy," "passionate," and "humbled to announce" shapes your voice by subtraction.
- **Point of view, recurring.** The ideas you return to. Mine are reinvention, being misread, precision over decoration. Yours are the themes you cannot stop writing about. Let them repeat. Repetition is how a voice becomes recognizable.

Voice is not personality. It is decisions.

People treat voice like a mystical quality you either have or do not, the way some people are charming. It is not. Voice is the sum of choices you make over and over until they become a pattern a reader can recognize. That is good news, because decisions can be learned and patterns can be built on purpose. You do not have to wait to discover your voice. You can decide it, sentence by sentence, and the deciding becomes the having.

The build-your-voice exercise, expanded

Write 150 words about your work with zero editing. Then highlight the three phrases that sound most like **you** and least like a template. Now go further. Ask: what do those three phrases have in common? Are they funny? Plainspoken? A little fierce? Warm? That common quality is the thread of your voice. Pull it. Write three more sentences that lean into that quality on purpose. You are not inventing anything. You are amplifying the part of you that was always going to be on the page if you stopped sanding it off.

Your no-fly list

Write down ten words and phrases you will never use again. Not because they are wrong, but because they are everyone's. Mine includes "synergy," "humbled to announce," "circle back," "leverage" as a verb, "passionate about," "thought leader," "in today's fast-paced world," "needless to say," "at the end of the day," and "results-driven." Yours will differ. The point is that a no-fly list does as much for your voice as a vocabulary. A voice is shaped as much by restraint as by reach.

Borrowing without sounding borrowed

Find three writers whose voices you love, in or out of your field. Do not imitate their content; study their moves. How long are their sentences? How often do they use a one-line paragraph for emphasis? Do they ask questions? Do they use humor to land a serious point? Steal the **moves**, not the words, and run them through your own diction and point of view. Every distinctive voice is a remix of admired moves plus the things only you would say.

“*Positioning gets you considered. Voice gets you remembered. You need both, and only one of them can't be stolen.*”

Do The Work

1. Do the 150-word free-write. Highlight your three truest phrases. Name the common thread.
2. Write your ten-item no-fly list and tape it above your desk.
3. Pick three voices you admire and write down one specific move from each. Use one of those moves in your next post.

CHAPTER FIVE: THE LINKEDIN AUDIT CHECKLIST

LinkedIn is where most of these rooms have a side entrance. Most profiles are obituaries, a list of where you used to work, written in the third-person passive voice of HR. Let's audit yours. Open your profile and go line by line.

The Headshot & Banner

- [] Does your photo look like a person you would want to talk to, or a hostage proof-of-life? Approachable beats stiff.
- [] Is your banner working, a line of positioning, a proof point, or is it the default blue void? The banner is free real estate; use it for your one-liner.

The Headline (the highest-leverage line on the platform)

- [] Does it say more than your job title? "Marketing Manager at X" is a wasted headline.
- [] Does it use the three-layer formula, what you do, for whom, with an edge?
- **Before:** "Senior Brand Manager | MBA | Marketing Professional"
- **After:** "I make overlooked brands impossible to ignore | Brand strategy for founders in their second act"

The About Section

- [] Does the first sentence earn the second? People only see two lines before "see more." Make line one a hook, not "I am a seasoned professional with..."

- [] Is it first person and conversational, or stiff and third-person?
- [] Is there at least one specific proof, a number, a name, a result?
- [] Is there a point of view, a belief, a line of actual personality?
- [] Is there a clear next step at the end (DM me, here's my site, here's how to work with me)?

The Experience Section

- [] Have you rewritten at least your current role to describe **outcomes and beliefs**, not duties? "Responsible for managing" is the language of a job description. You are not applying, you are positioning.
- [] Did you cut anything that no longer serves the room you want to be in? You are allowed to deprioritize the old self.

The Overall Test

- [] Read the whole profile aloud. Count how many sentences you would actually say to a human. If it is under half, rewrite until it is not.
- [] Hand it to a friend who knows you. Ask: "Does this sound like me?" If they hesitate, your voice is not on the page yet.

Run this once a quarter. Positioning drifts as you grow; the profile should keep up.

The featured section nobody uses

Most people leave the Featured section empty, which is like having a trophy shelf and keeping it in a closet. Pin the three things that prove your positioning: your best post, a piece of work you are proud of, a link to how to hire or read you. The Featured section is where a curious visitor goes from "interesting" to "I should reach out," but only if there is something there to push them. Fill it.

Do The Work

1. Run the full checklist above, top to bottom, and fix every unchecked box in one sitting. Do not save it for later; later is where profiles go to stay outdated.
2. Rewrite your headline using the three-layer formula. This single line is the highest-leverage edit on the platform.
3. Fill your Featured section with three things that prove your claim.

CHAPTER SIX: OBJECTIONS, FEAR, AND THE VOICE IN YOUR HEAD

Somewhere around now, a voice in your head starts negotiating. It wants you to keep the camouflage. Here are its favorite arguments, and the answers.

"If I get this specific, I will lose opportunities." You will lose opportunities that were never going to convert, and you will gain the ones that will. A narrow, sharp positioning does not shrink your pipeline; it raises its quality. You are trading a wide trickle of indifferent leads for a narrow stream of people who feel understood. That is a trade you want.

"This feels like bragging." There is a difference between bragging and being clear. Bragging is unearned superiority ("I'm the best in the business"). Clarity is a specific, true claim ("I wrote the campaign that doubled their trial signups"). One is air; the other is evidence. State the evidence plainly. Letting people underestimate you is not humility. It is a disservice to the people who need exactly what you do and cannot find you in the fog.

"What if I change? What if this is not me in a year?" Then you will rewrite it. Your positioning is not a tattoo. It is a current best statement of who you are and who you serve, and it should evolve as you do. The worst outcome is not outgrowing your bio. The worst outcome is staying invisible because you were waiting to be permanently sure.

"I am not a writer." You do not need to be a writer. You need to be clear, and clarity is not a talent, it is a process, the one in this book. Specific beats eloquent every time. A plain true sentence outperforms a beautiful vague one in every room that matters.

The reframe that makes it possible

Stop thinking of this as self-promotion and start thinking of it as service. Somewhere right now there is a person with the exact problem you solve, and they are scrolling past you because your words did not tell them you were the answer. Clarity is how they find you. When you write yourself plainly into the room, you are not showing off. You are making yourself findable to the people you are meant to help. That reframe turns the fear down enough to write the true thing.

Do The Work

1. Write down the objection that is loudest for you right now. Then write its answer in your own words. You will need it the next time you go quiet.
2. Find the one true, specific proof you have been too "humble" to state. Put it in your bio today.

CHAPTER SEVEN: THE THIRTY-DAY WRITE-YOURSELF-IN PLAN

Knowing is not the same as doing. This is the schedule that turns this book into a repositioned public presence in a month. Twenty to forty minutes a day. No need to announce anything; just do the work and let the change be visible.

Week One — Decide.

- Day 1: Camouflage audit (Chapter One). Score your current bio.
- Day 2: Layer One and Two (Chapter Two).
- Day 3: Layer Three, the edge. Finish the three edge sentences.
- Day 4: Assemble your full positioning statement. Read it to one person.
- Day 5: Rest and let it settle. Notice where it still feels fuzzy.

Week Two — Write.

- Day 6: Bio Template A (third person).
- Day 7: Bio Template B (first person).
- Day 8: Bio Template C (the one-liner).
- Day 9: The 150-word voice free-write and your no-fly list.
- Day 10: Choose three admired voices, steal three moves.

Week Three — Rebuild the profile.

- Day 11: New LinkedIn headline.
- Day 12: New About section.
- Day 13: Rewrite your current role for outcomes, not duties.
- Day 14: Banner and Featured section.

- Day 15: Read the whole profile aloud; cut every sentence you would not say.

Week Four — Go public.

- Days 16 to 20: Write five short posts, each built on one of your recurring themes (Layer Three in motion).
- Days 21 to 25: Publish two of them. Reply to every comment in your real voice.
- Days 26 to 28: Update one more surface, your website, your email signature, a speaker bio.
- Day 29: Ask one trusted person, "Does this sound like me now?"
- Day 30: Re-run the camouflage audit from Day 1. Watch the score fall.

Repeat the audit every quarter. You are not done; you are current.

CHAPTER EIGHT: FROM PAGE TO ROOM

Writing yourself in is not a one-time edit. It is a posture. Here is how to keep the door open once you have written your way through it.

Say the specific thing in public, repeatedly. The point of view from Layer Three is not just for your bio, it is for your posts, your talks, your replies. Repeat your themes until people associate them with your name. That association *is* being in the room.

Let the wrong people leave. Sharp positioning will lose you the people who were never going to hire, read, or champion you. Good. They were taking up space the right people could not fill. Precision costs you the indifferent and earns you the devoted.

Update as you become. The bio you wrote this year will feel small next year if you are growing. That is not failure, it is evidence. Rewrite as you reinvent. The page should always be slightly ahead of who you were and exactly level with who you are becoming.

Build a small swipe file of your own best lines. Every time you write a sentence about your work that makes you think "yes, that's exactly it," save it. Within a few months you will have a personal library of language you can pull from for any bio, post, or pitch. Most people start from a blank page every time. You will start from your own best self.

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The room was never locked. You just had not written the sentence that opened it yet. Now you have. Walk in.

APPENDIX: THE TEMPLATES, IN ONE PLACE

Tear these out. They are the whole book on one shelf.

Positioning statement: "I'm a [category] for [specific who, doing specific what], who believes [edge]."

Third-person bio: [Name] + [positioning] + [one proof with a number or name] + [belief] + [human detail].

First-person bio: [What I do, plainly] + [for whom] + [the belief] + [one line of personality].

One-liner: [I help / I write] + [specific who] + [specific outcome], with a little teeth.

LinkedIn headline: [What you do] + [for whom] + [edge], separated by pipes.

The three edge sentences: "Most people in my field think ____, but I think ____." / "The advice everyone gives that I disagree with is ____." / "The thing I refuse to do, even though it is standard, is ____."

The dinner-table test: Read it aloud. If you would not say it to a friend across a table, rewrite it until you would.

KEEP GOING

Positioning is the start. Voice is the depth.

If you are ready to build a complete, documented voice, not just for yourself but for a brand, a company, a team that needs to sound like one person, **The Brand Voice Playbook** is the deep end of this pool. It is the premium, build-it-from-scratch companion to this guide.

And if the writing in this book stirred something bigger, a sense that the self you are positioning is itself mid-rewrite, start with **The Reinvention Workbook**.

More at **mkparrish.com**, where I help people stop sounding like everyone else and start sounding like the only option.

You were always qualified for the room. Now you are legible. That was the only thing missing.

— MK Parrish

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